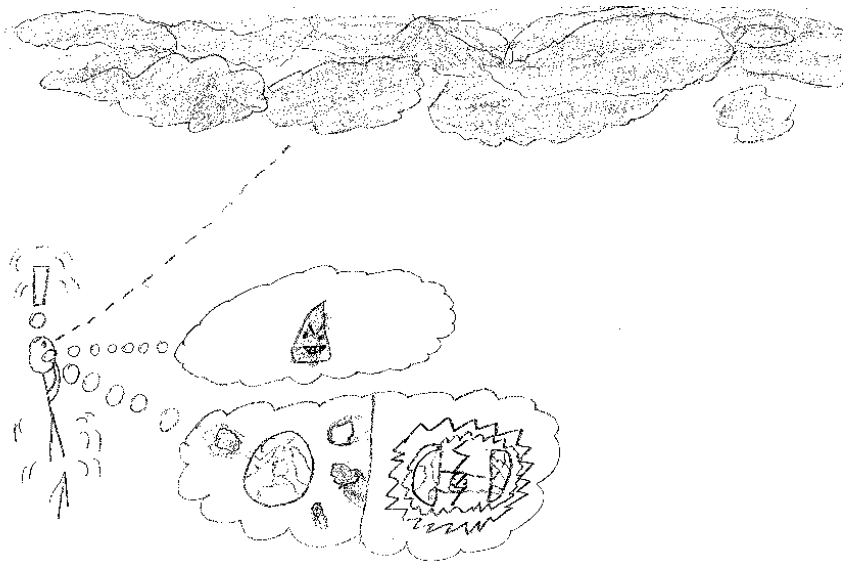
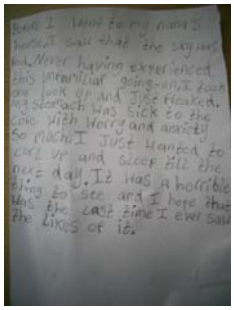
DERBYSHIRE County Council
Improving life for local people

A child or young person with autism in my setting.





"Before I went to my nana's house, I saw that the sky was red. Never having experienced this unfamiliar going-on, I took one look up and just freaked. My stomach was sick to the core with worry and anxiety so much, I just wanted to curl up and sleep till the next day. It was horrible thing to see and I hope that was the last time I ever see the likes of it."

"When shopping my worst fear came true – I got lost. It was unfamiliar surroundings and too big for me to get round. I heard my Mum shouting me, but my throat was too tight to answer. After I was found, I was shaking and tearful."

This booklet is based on “A child with autism in my class.” (2002) by

Margaret Ward, Primary Support Teaching Service.
Pat Smith, Derbyshire Educational Psychology Service.
Joyce Hart, Holbrook Centre for Autism.

From material prepared by the “Joined Up Training Group”

Jane Atkinson, Birdholme Infants School D+A Nursery
Rebecca Clubb, Speech and Language Therapist, N.Derbyshire CHS NHS Trust.
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Gail Puilling, Holbrook Centre for Autism

Which was updated in 2007 by

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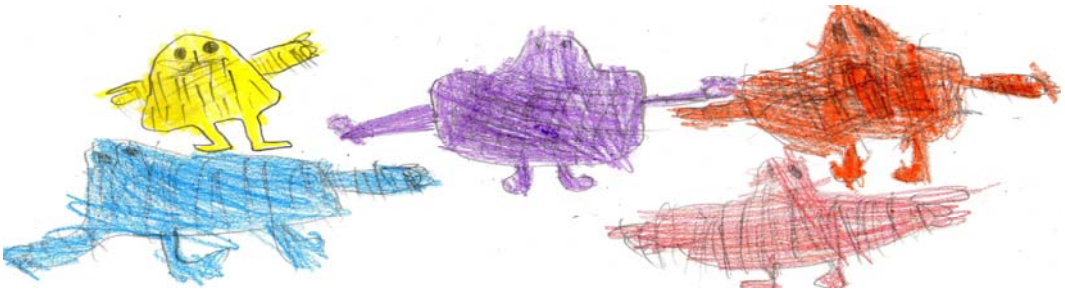
With thanks to :-

Andrea Higgins – Joint Principal Educational Psychologist, CAYA Derbyshire
Alison Hall – Autism Outreach, Peak School

Drawings in this booklet are by children and young people with Autism.
Please look at Pages 22 to 24 to read about these artists.



A child or young person with autism in my setting.

Using this booklet.

In order to make this booklet more personal and effective for settings working with children or young adults with autism, there are spaces to enter your own contributions, observations and working practices.

- The front cover can have a name and a picture.
- You will be able to take the general suggestions and make them an even better fit by adding more specific information.
- By doing this you will be able to improve the consistency of practice which is an advantage for all.
- This could be used for transitions from settings or from team member to team member and a record of your work.

Current considerations and approaches to supporting the child or young person with autism.

Every Child Matters (ECM) identifies the five outcomes that are most important to children and young people:

- Be healthy
- Stay safe
- Enjoy and achieve
- Make a positive contribution
- Achieve economic well-being

The five outcomes are universal ambitions for every child and young person, whatever their background or circumstances. Improving outcomes for all children and young people underpins all of the development and work within all settings.

The Common Assessment Framework (CAF) is a key part of delivering frontline services that are integrated and focused around the needs of children and young people. The CAF is a standardised approach to conducting an assessment of a child's additional needs and deciding how those needs should be met. It can be used by practitioners across children's services in England and will promote more effective, earlier identification of additional needs, particularly in universal services. It is intended to provide a simple process for a holistic assessment of a child's needs and strengths, taking account of the role of parents, carers and environmental factors on their development. Practitioners will then be better placed to agree, with the child and family, about what support is appropriate. The CAF will also help to improve integrated working by promoting co-ordinated service provision.

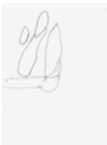
Problem behaviours in children and young people with autism require an emphasis on proactive strategies. It is important therefore that we develop a good understanding of the function behind the child's behaviour in order to address the problem effectively, rather than rely on reactive approaches which may not recognise the behaviour as being part of the child's autism. That is why the Multi-Element Plan (MEP) is a useful process by which we can analyse the underlying function of a child's behaviour and devise a structured intervention programme which can strike a balance between reacting to the problem and enabling us to intervene at an earlier stage to manage it more effectively.

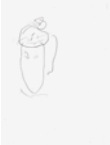
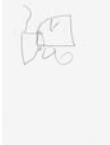
Multi-Element Plans are developed through a collaborative process, bringing together the views and knowledge of the parents, the professionals involved and the child in order to determine why the behaviour is taking place, what environmental changes would help reduce or eliminate it and what specific skills need to be taught.

In any situation, the views of the parents should be sought both to respect the significance of their contribution, the legal requirements to do so and to ensure a sucessful partnership. For the same reasons, the views of the child should be sought, often with the use of adaptive material like visual prompts for example.

Regardless of whether your setting is a pre-school, breakfast club, after school, holiday care or you are a child minder it is very important to prepare the other children or young people who attend before a new member who has autism attends. They need to be able to ask questions and understand that the new member sometimes may do or say things that they find unusual. Children may want to use a vocabulary that they are comfortable with that expresses support and respect. Their natural inclination to interest and kindness, balanced by a few simple rules, can be supportive and increase social learning for all concerned in your setting community.

For parents, the experience of a diagnosis of autism may be a time of personal difficulty. This has been compared to the experience of loss with many emotions like guilt, anger, apathy, grief and disbelief. For early year settings, when the diagnosis is made in the first years of a child's life, this may be a difficult time though later diagnosis may have other particular difficulties. Each experience for a parent is unique so it is important to be prepared to accept, acknowledge and adapt to the feelings that this experience brings. Personal attributes of listening, showing care and understanding, giving time and responding to needs are most valued as aspects of support beyond the entitlements of the service a setting provides.



An Autism Friendly Setting and The Emotional Friendly Setting

The people

In any setting there are often a number of different people involved which can present some challenges. To be autism friendly it is very important to remember

- Everyone needs to be autism aware
- Approaches identified should be consistently applied by all adults
- Be clear about everyone's role and responsibilities.

The Physical Environment:

- Children need to feel safe
- Parents need to feel their child will be safe
- Children need an 'escape' option somewhere that they know they can go to when it all becomes too much.
- Some children find large open spaces difficult to cope with – show them a specific place where they can go when outside and encourage them to use it.
- Try and monitor the noise levels occasionally – very noisy settings can cause many children to become anxious and stressed not just those who are autistic.

Organisation:

- Establish routines, teach routines and stick to routine.

TIPS for an Emotionally Friendly setting

- Staff are aware and able to control their emotions – no shouting.
- Behavioral Expectations are clear, fair and understood by all.
- Staff are aware of and understand the nature of autism
- Praise, reward and positive comments are used constantly.
- Individual Strengths are acknowledged
- Parents are welcomed and respected.
- Parents know who to go to, to talk about things, big or little.
- Children are taught about emotions.

Information and ideas.

Autism, Autistic Spectrum Disorder (ASD) or Autistic Spectrum Condition (ASC) are some of the current terms used to describe this neurobiological, lifelong condition. As a spectrum condition, children or young people have a wide range of abilities and behaviours.

Asperger Syndrome (AS) is part of the autistic condition, similar to autism except that these children or young persons usually have higher intellectual abilities and better language development than the majority of children with a diagnosis of autism. There is theoretical debate over whether AS is the same as high-functioning autism. The main clinical features of AS are a lack of empathy and difficulties in understanding the reciprocal nature of conversations and relationships. Individuals can be pedantic with repetitive speech and develop an intense fascination for certain topics. Many are clumsy and have co-ordination problems and difficulties in attending to more than one task simultaneously.

The incidence for autism is thought to be at around 1 in 100 with a ratio of 4:1 males to females for autism and 10:1 males to females for AS. Autism can be associated sometimes with many other conditions including Attention Deficit Disorder and epilepsy. It is genetically linked in some cases. It is NOT the result of emotional deprivation or emotional stress due in any way to parental rejection or 'cold parenting', a willful desire to avoid social contact, class or culture related, a mental illness or misunderstood genius.

The key areas for support, the "Triad of Impairments" plus Sensory are

- Language and Communication (Pages 7 – 9)
- Social Interaction and Relationships (Pages 10 - 11)
- Flexibility and Resistance to change (Page 12)
- Sensory Difficulties (Pages 13 – 19)

These areas of impairment overlap and have impact on behaviour, learning and social interaction in many settings and at home.

Remember

- Results and progress can be slow. Do not give up or be discouraged. Relationships may take time to form.
- All children and young people with autism are unique, what works for one may not work for another.
- Be consistent, persistent and reflective in your approach.
- Tomorrow is another day!

There is a considerable amount of information on autism. Some of the books and sources, which go into far more detail, are listed at the back of this booklet.

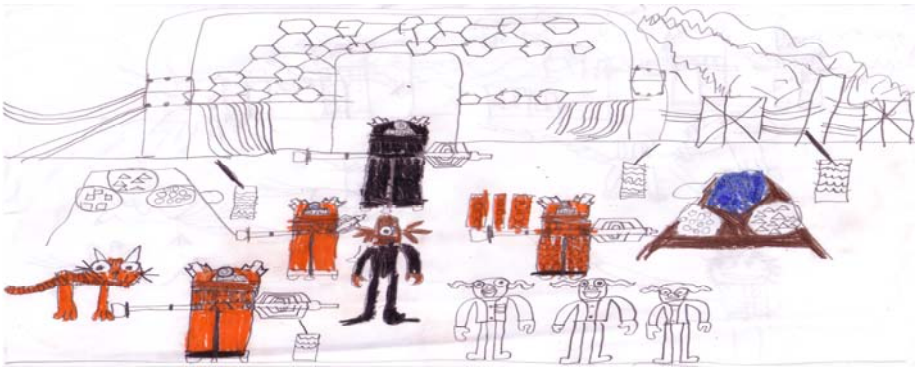
Language and Communication

- The child or young person with autism may have superficially good spoken language, though it may seem formal and pedantic.
- Their voice may lack expression.

- Some children or young people may have no spoken language and communicate by other means, for example actions, signs, gestures or pictures.
- The child or young person may have difficulties understanding the meanings of words particularly the more abstract concepts.
- They often have difficulties following longer sentences and instructions.
- There may be difficulties in listening and attention which may limit understanding.

- In reading the child or young person may be fluent, but with little understanding, sometimes called “Hyperlexia”.
- The child may understand others in a literal way, without understanding the implications of what has been said.

- The child is limited in their use of non-verbal communication and often cannot make sense of the gestures, facial expressions and body language of others.



The specific Language and Communication ability of _____

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TIPS for Language.

- Address the child by name : children with asd often have difficulty knowing that an instruction for a whole group means them as well.
- Direct the child to listen : children with asd will not listen to language not specifically directed at them or when there is other noise.
- Keep it simple : Ask one thing at a time, for example, “Get the book” is better than “Go and have a look and see if you can find me the book”
- Use Visual Timetables : This is valuable when there are changes. Keep in place for reference even when child seem to know the routine.
- Give the child time to process instructions : Do not jump straight in and repeat the instruction again. If you do repeat it, use the same exact words.
- Give positive instructions : Tell the child what you want them to do, for example, “Fold your arms.”, rather than “Don’t tap!”.
- Back up spoken language : with gesture, demonstration, pictures or objects.
- Model simple language at the child’s level in context : Say it how they would if they could.
- Be specific about the start and finish of activities : Give a countdown to end an activity…
- Be literal : Say what you mean and mean what you say. Avoid sarcasm and teasing. Avoid or explain figures of speech.
- Be sensitive and reward : the child’s attempts to communicate.

Specific Tips for Language for _____

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TIPS for Communication

- Understand : that children may feel threatened by the close proximity of others – especially those of their own age.
- Go at the child's pace : when trying to develop interaction. Notice their interests and follow their lead to develop attention and turn taking.
- Identify what the child likes and dislikes socially: Use this knowledge when planning activities.
- Give the child time to know you : Do not confuse with too many changes of personnel. The child is more likely to interact with familiar people.
- Keep facial expressions and gestures simple and clear : Match your face to your words.
- Ensure a consistent approach : all adults in the setting to be aware of strategies and to respond in the same way.
- Have a briefing sheet : for others who may turn up.
- Make social interaction an objective in planning : Use turn taking, social games and teach appropriate language for joining in a game.
- Work on attention and listening skills : Ensure your expectations of the child's attention are within their capability.
- Create situations : where the child has to ask other children for something, for example, asking for the right coloured pencil. Do not let the adult anticipate every need.
- Give the child a special place on the carpet : marked with a patch or carpet square. This should be on the edge of the group away from noise, movement, playthings and with a clear view of the adult and visual supports.

Specific Tips for Communication for _____

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Social Interaction and Relationships

- The child or young person may be socially isolated amongst their peer group and may not be worried about this. However, when they wish to join in with their peers, they may become upset or concerned about it because they lack the strategies and skills to develop and sustain friendships.

- The child or young person may feel tense and anxious if others approach them and make social demands.

- The child or young person may fail to pick up social cues and unwritten rules. This makes them appear different and prone to teasing, ridicule and bullying. Often they may fail to realise that they are being bullied. There is a real need to look further and with more care for signs that the child or young person with autism may be being bullied.

- Bullying is a real and current issue with resulting devastating effects on self esteem causing real unhappiness even if the child or young person is not able to express this feeling. The experience of bullying may lead to anxious behaviour, changes in sleep patterns, outbursts in other settings especially at home, avoidance of similar experiences and increased withdrawal.

- The signs of bullying are common to all children and young persons but these may be more indicative of a problem when the bullied child or person cannot communicate the events. These signs are physical like bruises or scratches, damage to property or loss of money, changes in routine around going to the setting or a reluctance to go, being stressed, depressed, unhappy or unwell and deterioration in concentration or the standard of work or social interaction reported by others around them.

- Bullying behaviour may be copied due to a lack of social understanding as to the actions carried out. This can also include being set up by others to perform in certain ways like using inappropriate language or gestures. Behaving aggressively, becoming frustrated or trying to control a play situation can present as bullying.

- The child or young person may behave or use language in a socially inappropriate way, e.g. they may speak to adults and peers in the same manner, making personal comments or remarks.

TIPS for helping with Social Interaction and Relationships

- Understand that the child or young person may feel threatened by the close proximity of others – especially those of their own age.
- Allow time for solitary reflection.
- Proceed at the child or young person's pace when trying to develop interaction.

- o Identify what the young person likes and dislikes socially – use this knowledge when planning events.
- o Give them time to get to know you and don't confuse the child or young person with many changes of personnel.

- ▪ Watch for those who subtly annoy the child or young person with ASD. Keep them apart wherever possible. Be aware of the child or young person's potential for victimisation as they may be seen as a target for bullying and teasing.
- ▪ Establish a 'buddy' system where the child or young person is paired with appropriate peers.

- Ensure that both adults and peers allow as much independence as is appropriate.
- Be aware that the child or young person may be defensive of their own personal space but have no understanding of others personal space.

- Build up specific skills through everyday activities where the child or young person has the chance to copy or model their behaviour on others.
- Use interests and strengths to encourage the development of interaction and relationships.

- Teach social skills to encourage social interaction through paired and group work to develop turn taking, waiting, greetings, joining in with others, joking and teasing.
- Consider addressing new ideas or rules in one to one situations if necessary.
- Develop behavioural strategies which concentrate on unacceptable behaviour (biting) rather than unusual behaviours (lining things up).

Specific Tips for Social Interaction and Relationships for _____

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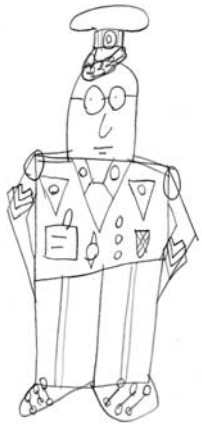
Flexibility and Resistance to Change



- The child or young person may have an all absorbing interest which peers find unusual.
- The child or young person may insist on sticking to certain routines.
- The development of their ability to think and to play creatively may be limited.
- The child or young person may have difficulties in generalising skills from one setting to another. For example, something as simple as using a cup.

TIPS for improving Flexibility and Resistance to change.

- Provide : a predictable and safe environment.
- Use : a consistent approach to tasks.
- Help : the child or young person understands what is expected by having clear predictable routines presented visually.
- Reduce : distractions related to noise, smell and vision.
- Organise and prepare for changes: such as moving from one situation, place or person to another, so the child or young person knows what is happening and what they have to do.
- Avoid surprises : by preparing thoroughly and in advance for special activities, altered activities or other changes, regardless of how minimal.
- Introduce : any changes gradually with good communication.
- Help : explain changes by giving visual clues, using simple drawings.
- Remember : an increase in unusual difficulties or behaviour probably indicates an increase in stress.
- Talk or draw : through stressful situations or remove the child from the stressful situation.
- Make : a special interest manageable, limit it and try to use it positively.
- Transition : Prepare carefully and in advance for movement between settings.

Specific Tips for improving Flexibility and Resistance to Change for _____

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Sensory Differences

Children and young people with ASD often process sensory information differently, so learning how their senses are working can help us understand them better.

Some children and young people with ASD may be overly sensitive to information coming through any of their five senses of sight, hearing, touch, smell and taste.

- This can result in sensory overload, where the child or young person experience sensations so intensely that they can feel overwhelmed by them. For some, the mere anticipation of such experiences can induce a state of panic.

- In contrast, there are some children and young people with ASD who are under-stimulated by sensory information. For some, this is indicated by their lack of reaction to pain.

- Sensory processing differences often lead to behaviours in a child that we would find difficult to interpret. Having an awareness of the child's sensory experiences is therefore crucial.

- Children with sensory differences may also have difficulty with sensory integration. This means that they may find it hard to cope with combining all their sensory experiences. They may also find it difficult to filter out different sensory information so that they cannot prevent different aspects of it catching their attention, whether they want it to or not.

The specific Sensory Differences of _____

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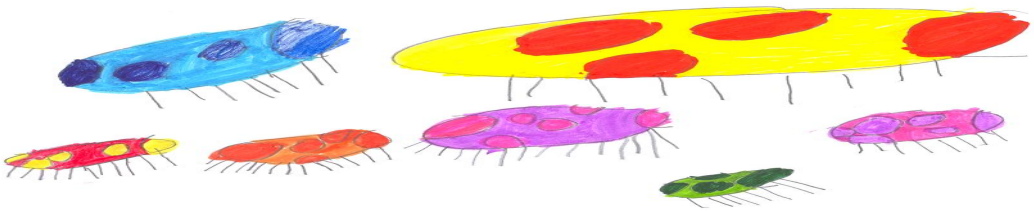

Sensitivity to sound

- Children and young persons with ASD may be sensitive to certain sounds, particularly if they are sudden and unexpected or if they are of a certain pitch.

- They may find it hard to manage in noisy environments where a lot of people are talking.

- You may see some children and young persons covering their ears or looking distressed. They may run away from the source of the sound. They may also experience anxiety in anticipation of the noise as well as during and after the experience.

Specific observations of Sensory Differences for _____

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TIPS for Sensitivity to Sound.

- Provide the child or young person with a quiet area : where they can get away from the hustle and bustle of lively, noisy environments when they need to.

- Teach the child to go to this quiet area before they become overwhelmed. It is also useful to build in a sufficient number of times in the day for the child to access this.

- Prepare the child or young person in advance for noises, where possible, when you know they will be exposed to them during the day, e.g., the vacuum cleaner, a workman's drill, a noisy train which passes by at a certain time.

- Experiment with earphones for children who are overly sensitive.

- Be aware of the effects of a big room or space such as a swimming pool or a playground may have on the noise-sensitive child.

- Teach new skills in a quiet, low distraction environment.

Specific Tips for Sensitivity to Sounds for _____

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Visual Sensitivity

- Some children and young persons with ASD may become over-stimulated by bright lights, vivid colours or patterns.
- Some may find it hard to pick out relevant details in pictures or diagrams.
- Some children and young people may also find it hard to look directly at an object, preferring to look out from the sides of their eyes.

What you can do to help:

- Develop an awareness of things that may visually over-stimulate the child/young person and reduce their exposure to such objects.
- Introduce activities that can be linked to the child or young person's visual preferences and interests.

Specific observations of visual sensitivity for _____

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Specific Tips for visual sensitivity

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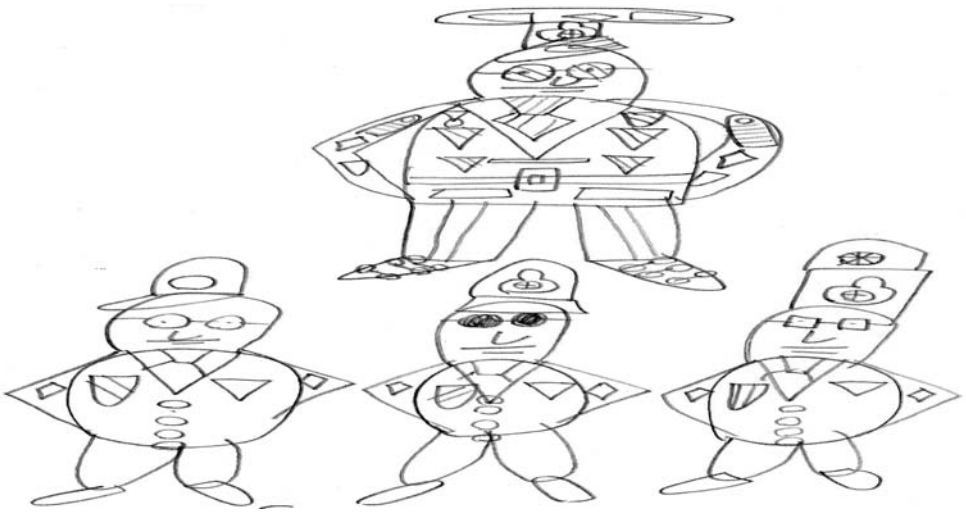

Sensitivity to Touch

- Some children and young people who are hyper-sensitive to touch may find it hard being touched by others, whether this is deliberate or accidental.

- They may also find it hard to touch certain textures. Their sensitivity can also cause them to experience significant discomfort when wearing certain clothing made out of materials they find hard to tolerate. Labels on clothing may also be a source of discomfort and distress.

- Touch sensitivity may also extend to children experiencing discomfort when sitting on certain surfaces, either on furniture or carpets.

- Children with touch sensitivity can also find it hard to cope with having their hair brushed or washed and their nails cut.

- Children who are under-stimulated by touch may seek more intense sensory feedback through firm pressure.

What you can do to help:

- Become aware of the child's sensory needs by observing them carefully.

- Remove labels from clothing and dress the child/young person in clothing made from materials they find comfortable.

Specific observations of sensitivity to touch for _____

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Specific Tips for sensitivity to touch

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Smell and Taste Sensitivity

- Many children and young people with ASD are particularly sensitive to certain smells and tastes. For instance, they might find certain perfumes overpowering and offensive which other people typically consider pleasant.

- Some might be over-stimulated by certain smells, causing them to become very active.

- Some children and young people with ASD cannot tolerate certain food textures or flavours. For instance, some children may only eat crunchy foods while others may only tolerate smooth textures. They may also only want to eat certain brands or foods that are a particular colour.

- You may also find that some children choose to eat unusual substances, like paper.

What you can do to help:

- Develop an awareness of the odours, tastes and food textures that the child or young person finds difficult to tolerate.

- Remember, every child is different, so there are no set rules for how they will respond to different sensory information. It is therefore important to watch them carefully in order to tune into their sensory world.

Specific observations of smell and taste sensitivity for _____

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Specific Tips for smell and taste sensitivity

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Vestibular

There is a collection of structures within the inner ear which detect movement and the sensation of movement. This coordinates the movement of the eyes, the head and the body including the coordination of the two sides of the body and also helps with balance. This tells us if we are moving, in which direction we are moving and whether or not we are upright.

Children or young persons who are hypersensitive to vestibular stimulation may fear 'ordinary 'movements, for example slides and ramps.

Those who are hyposensitive to vestibular stimulation enjoy intense stimulation, for example spinning, rocking and jumping.

The associated behaviour we see may be their means of balancing their bodies. For example, they may need to undertake spinning activity as a means for them to be able to engage in 'normal' tasks as this can stabilise and enable their learning.

What you might see

- Poor tolerance of movement <u>or</u> increased tolerance to movement
- May have motion sickness <u>or</u> unlikely to get dizzy
- May exhibit anxiety when feet are off the ground <u>or</u> be a risk taker
- Hate being upside down <u>or</u> craves head being upside down
- Dislikes unpredictable movement of playground equipment <u>or</u> craves the exciting movement of playground equipment
- Holds on to others or rails for support <u>or</u> constantly needs movement
- May be slow and cautious <u>or</u> again take risks

Activities that might influence vestibular control

- Swinging
- Rocking
- Rolling backwards and forwards
- Roundabouts
- Trampolines
- Core stability exercises

Let child lead and have control over their movement.

Proprioceptive

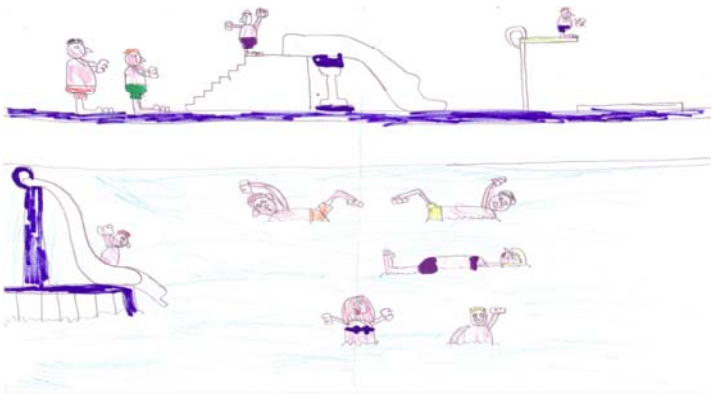
The proprioceptive sense provides feedback to the brain from muscles and joints. It provides information about body parts in relation to self and space as well as information to the joints to assist in the application of appropriate pressure to carry out specific tasks. It also allows the body to plan movement efficiently.

What you might see

- Clumsiness, stiff movements
- Tires easily—effort in movement
- Appears to have weak muscles
- Tendency to fall
- Props to support self, sprawls on desk, difficulty sitting still/upright
- Lack of awareness of body space
- Odd body posture
- Difficulty with fine motor co-ordination. Weak or ineffective grasp affecting ability to write, draw, sign, manipulate cutlery or fasten clothes
- Poor rhythm or timing of movement
- Difficulty judging the amount of pressure to exert
- Needs lots of movement to know where they are in space

What to do

- Encourage more movement in general.
- Trampoline work
- Swimming
- Stair climbing
- ‘Heavy’ work for example carrying books, wiping board, moving furniture.
- Use playground equipment like climbing frames, balance beams, swings and roundabouts



Finding out more

www.nas.org.uk The National Autism Society of UK champion the rights and interests of all people with autism and aim to provide individuals with autism and their families with help, support and services that they can access, trust and rely upon and which can make a positive difference to their lives. The on line shop is a good source of current publications.

www.teacch.com TEACCH is an evidence-based service, training, and research program for individuals of all ages and skill levels with autism spectrum disorders that has worked with thousands of individuals with autism spectrum disorders and their families.

www.pecs.org.uk the UK branch of Pyramid Educational Consultants. Home of PECS - The Picture Exchange Communication, a communication form using visual materials.

www.thegraycenter.org The official homesite of Carol Gray and Social Stories, an effective method to teach social and emotional skills.

For advice In Derby and Derbyshire

Parent Partnership, The Community Centre, School Board Lane, Brampton, Chesterfield, Derbyshire, S40 1DD Tel: 01246 273154
www.derbyshireparentpartnership.co.uk
parent.partnership@derbyshire.gov.uk

There are four commissioned services funded by Derbyshire.

Fairplay, Suite 2, First Floor 67/77 Chatsworth Road, Chesterfield, Derbyshire, S40 2AL Tel : 01246 203963 www.fair-play.co.uk
office@fair-play.co.uk

Derbyshire Autism Support Group, 28d High Street, Ripley, Derbyshire, DE5 3HH Tel : 01773 741221 www.autismsupport.co.uk
dasg@autismsupport.co.uk

Buxton Volunteer Centre, 16 Eagle Parade, Buxton, Derbyshire, SK17 6EQ
Tel : 01298 23970 www.buxtonvc.org.uk volunteering@buxtonvc.org.uk

Umbrella Information Office, Ronnie MacKeith Child Development Centre, Derby City General Hospital, Uttoxeter Road, Derby, DE22 3NE
Tel : 01332 785658 www.umbrella.uk.net umbrella@derbyhospitals.nhs.uk

There are many books on Autism and this list is just some to read.

For Siblings and Family :

My brother is different: a book for young children who have brothers and sisters with autism. Author: Louise Gorrod. Published by The National Autistic Society, 1997, 20pp, pbk, illustrated. ISBN: 978 1 89928 050 6

My sister is different. Author: Sarah Tamsin Hunter. Published by The National Autistic Society, 2006, 24pp, pbk, illustrated in colour. ISBN: 978 1 89928 098 8

I am special: introducing children and young people to their autistic spectrum disorder. Author: Peter Vermeulen. Published by Jessica Kingsley Publishers, 2000, 240pp, A4, pbk ISBN: 978 1 85302 916 5 Code: NAS 394

For Professionals :

The complete guide to Asperger's syndrome. Author: Tony Attwood Published by Jessica Kingsley Publishers, 2008, pbk ISBN: 978 1 84310 495 7

Autism spectrum disorders: the complete guide. Author: Chantal Sicile-Kira. Published by Vermillion, 2003, pbk. ISBN: 978 1 85302 915 8

Autism and Asperger syndrome: the facts. Author: Simon Baron-Cohen Published by Oxford University Press, 2008, 157pp, pbk. ISBN: 978 0 19 850490 0

What's so special about autism? Author: Lorna Wing Published by The National Autistic Society, 2006, 30pp, pbk. ISBN: 978 1 905722 42 6

For Parents :

Asperger's syndrome: from diagnosis to solutions - a guide for parents Author: Phyllis Quigg and Oonagh Nugent Foreword: Tony Attwood Published by Down Lisburn Trust, 2005, 32pp, A5, pbk, illustrated ISBN: 978 1 89928 078 0

How to help your autistic spectrum child: practical ways to make life run more smoothly Author: Jackie Brealy and Beverly Davies Published by White Ladder Press, 2006, 182pp, pbk ISBN: 978 1 90541 005 7

Caring for a child with autism: a practical guide for parents Author: Martine Ives and Nell Munro Published by Jessica Kingsley Publishers, 2002, 304pp, pbk, illustrated. ISBN: 978 1 85302 996 7

The drawings are by a child or young person with autism.

Front and endpiece : House Page 2 : TV Characters by Thomas Banks.

"For Tom, the doing of a drawing is more important than the finished product. The pencil, which can produce an interesting tapping sound, can give the basic outline but it is the colouring in that needs the most care. Space has to be identified and, if it is too large, needs partitioning. You can see some of this in the red house. Edges pose a challenge but Tom worked out how to mark these and then colour up to them. A picture like this, once started, has to be finished. The colours have their own places so the sky can only come down to the top of the brown roof. Tom definitely did not want people in his drawing of the house. He got great pleasure from the movement of the crayons and remembering the chimney. Tom likes ideas to expand his pictures but knows what he likes and what fits for him. Drawing TV characters enables him to enact the story as he draws." - William Morris SSSEN

Page 4 Yacht / Cat / Cat / Train by Francis Jeffrey

"Francis based his stories on fictional stories. He finds it difficult to draw a picture from memory so needs prompting by being shown a similar picture. He is often better at drawing from a story he knows as it has more meaning for him. So he can draw a house from the three little pigs story that he knows but would struggle to just draw a house. He is working on putting the features onto a face and at the moment everything he does has to pretty much be copied." Josie Jeffries SSSEN

Pages 12 and 15 Policemen by Sean Pearce

"Sean loves people in uniform and has a thing about the Police, Fire and Ambulance Services. He loves to dress up in uniform. The chief of the police force has more medals and stripes. The three smaller policemen, all started as a body then three heads were added and finally the legs. The faces all had glasses but all different. He also decided they needed different hats. He might have had some contact with an actual policeman with glasses. He then decided that the three policemen could not answer to the chief of police but needed a sergeant with a few more medals and, again, glasses." - Sally Jackson, Autism Outreach.

Page 16 Insect by Adam Mace

"Adam enjoys expressing himself through drawing and is particularly good at recall of small details. This was done during a class topic on minibeasts. Seeing the small detail (and not the whole picture) reflects the autism. He likes non-fiction topics that present things factually. He can do very well at these things because there is no deduction or inference involved. He gets very involved when he is doing his

drawings. Again we use drawings a lot to explain social situations and emotions (comic strip conversations). He uses drawing to set up a visual timetable." Ann Worrall SSSEN

Pages 3, 7 and 9 Dr Who and Batman by Reece Oakley

"Reece enjoys drawing and it is his "comfort" zone, his area of security, his motivator. Drawing is always his "choose" at the end of a set task, and Reece will always work well in order to earn five minutes drawing time at the end of a task. He always uses felt tip pens kept in a special box to draw his pictures and these have to be put on the table where he can see them, together with the paper. He draws the pictures freehand and is very specific about the colours he uses for the characters - he uses the same colours each time and will not accept variations in shade. He will go and search out a particular shade if it is not in the box for whatever reason. He began to watch Dr.Who and these characters became the subject of his drawing. Most recently he has drawn Batman after seeing the film and working with Batman Lego - hence the Batman pictures are very "square". Reece prefers Batman Lego pictures - standard Batman pictures will not do! I gave him a picture of Batman and he said "Its very nice, Mrs. Williams but I like Lego Batman" and gave the picture back to me." Linda Williams SSSEN

Pages 8 and 13 Animals by James Adey

"James loves drawing - especially characters that he has seen on the television or on computer games. He usually draws with great detail and makes his pictures very colourful. At school James likes working with numbers and using the computer, but he has made most progress lately in his writing skills. James's parents actually sent the pictures in to school from home and were very happy for them to be used." - Jane Clamp SSSEN

Page 1 Lost and Red Sky by Jack Brown

"When shopping my worst fear came true – I got lost. It was unfamiliar surroundings and too big for me to get round. I heard my Mum shouting me, but my throat was too tight to answer. After I was found, I was shaking and tearful."

"Before I went to my nana's house, I saw that the sky was red. Never having experienced this unfamiliar going-on, I took one look up and just freaked. My stomach was sick to the core with worry and anxiety so much, I just wanted to curl up and sleep till the next day. It was horrible thing to see and I hope that was the last time I ever see the likes of it."
- Jack himself.

Page 18 Person by Dylan Nolan

"Dylan has a very clear picture of what he wants to draw and concentrates very hard to get his ideas on paper. When drawing from memory he will usually focus on a cartoon characters he knows and is very exact about the details he includes. When copying a picture he likes to include every detail and will take his time to ensure that he can be as close to the original as possible. Dylan has a darker style influenced by graphic novels and playstation games. Although he finds them scary, he says it's less scary than the real world because in the real world you can't tell by looking at someone if they are good or bad."
- Caroline Bell, Holbrook Centre for Autism

Page 19 Swimming by Lewis O' Callaghan

"Lewis is influenced by very traditional cartoons and will often draw pictures of people he cares about tied to railway tracks and show himself riding to the rescue, then everyone sitting down to enjoy a roast chicken dinner."

"Lewis finds drawing a way of chilling out and relaxing. He usually adopts a child like style with a 'pirate' or 'trains' theme. It is repetitive but contains a lot of detail that he goes to great lengths to explain to anyone who shows interest. He is quite knowledgeable on animals and it helps reinforce his self confidence if he is able to narrate his drawings." – Ian Lees, Holbrook Centre for Autism